Badauni, ever the critic, this particular variety of mango, ‘for sweetness and flavor [was]
. . . not up to much’.

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Akbar, it seems, was not entirely pleased by what he heard of the battle. The emperor sent a man to examine the battlefield – upon which, in Amrit Rai’s description, ‘Severed limbs are likened to fish swimming in a pool of blood’[36] – and though he was ‘satisfied on the whole’ by whatever evidence he procured on the nature of the fight, he was unhappy that his army hadn’t chased after Rana Pratap.[37]

He may even have found the rana’s escape slightly suspicious. Two years later, in 1578, the Mughals were still pursuing the lord of Mewar, as they would until the day he died. They found and besieged him in Kumbhalgarh fort, but now a new commander called Shahbaz Khan arrived. Shahbaz Khan took command of the siege – which he could hardly have done without Akbar’s blessing – and sent Man Singh and Bhagwant Das away, just in case ‘their feelings as landholders’, as Abul Fazl puts it delicately, were hampering the Rajputs’ mission.

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And so to the miracle of the azaan.

Kumbhalgarh is a grand old fortress, sprawling over more than 650 acres. In one of its nooks, there lived a hermit who had acquired some fame, and people ‘always sought blessing from his lofty spirit’. Now, however, his words came as a rude shock. At dawn, a few days before the Mughals attacked, the hermit climbed to the top of Rana Pratap’s temple and ‘sounded the azan’, the Muslim call to prayer, predicting an imperial victory. When the startled rana asked him what he was up to, the hermit said he had had a vision of a Mughal triumph. The rana ‘was enraged and put him to death’, Abul Fazl reports.

Indeed, the Mughals did win Kumbhalgarh – and Udaipur, too, the following day. It was a good showing, and Akbar would have been pleased; as pleased as he was with the hermit’s ‘Divine boon’.

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